

MAMIE. Father sent me here from the lighthouse to tell you. Rufus Norman shot the light out.

STEVE. Just as I thought.

MAMIE. But when he did the strong wind caught a big piece of broken glass and it sailed through the air and struck Rufus on the head and killed him.

SARAH. Glory be! Mamie, go tell your father to come over and have supper with us.

CAPTAIN (*To the audience.*) Next week we play "Uncle Tom's Cabin."

CURTAIN

A THIEF IN THE HOUSE

A Melodramatic Travesty

By
ARTHUR L. KASER

CHARACTERS

MRS. HARDNUT.....a wealthy dowager
GERALDINE LEMON.....her secretary
MARY JONES.....a poor but honest housemaid
HAROLD HARDNUT.....Mrs. Hardnut's nephew
JACK HART.....Mary's sweetheart
PINSETTI PENICILLI.....Harold's crooked pal

ABOUT THE CHARACTERS

MRS. HARDNUT—A buxom dowager. Overdressed and bejeweled. Uses lorgnette excessively. Is overbearing.

GERALDINE—Well dressed. Shifty eyes. Curl to lip. About twenty.

MARY—Eighteen years old. Honest and straightforward. Pretty, but inexpensively clothed.

HAROLD—A nicely dressed man of twenty-two. Subtle. Walks as if his feet pained him.

JACK—About twenty-one. New clothes but of an inferior quality. Clothes do not fit any too well.

PINSETTI—Swarthy complexion. First entrance, mediocre clothes. Later, policeman's coat and cap. Large belt that supports a sword, large hatchet and policeman's club. Carries shotgun and large revolver. Wears black mask over eyes.

SCENE: *Living room. Entrances at Left and Right stage. Library table up Center. Lamp and books on table. Left of table,*

against rear drop is large black wooden box to represent a safe. Dial painted on door, the door being hinged to box. Firecracker in box with fuse protruding through door. Up Right is davenport. Other pieces to dress stage.

AT THE RISE OF THE CURTAIN: Enter MRS. HARDNUT carrying a roll of wallpaper and squinting through lorgnette. Appears rather bored.

MRS. HARDNUT. Miss Lemon! Oh, Miss Lemon, are you there? (Enter GERALDINE, Right.)

GERALDINE. Yes, Mrs. Hardnut.

MRS. HARDNUT (Holding up wallpaper.) This just came and it is too late to place it in the bank.

GERALDINE. What is it?

MRS. HARDNUT. One million dollars worth of stock.

GERALDINE. Stock? It looks like a roll of wallpaper.

MRS. HARDNUT. It is Wall Street stock. It must be placed in the safe . . . (Indicating safe upstage.) . . . until tomorrow.

GERALDINE. One million dollars! That is a very valuable paper to have in the house overnight.

MRS. HARDNUT. No one will know it is here but you and me, and as my secretary you are supposed to keep your mouth shut.

GERALDINE. I've heard you talk pretty loud in your sleep.

MRS. HARDNUT (Hands paper to GERALDINE.) Young lady, remember your position.

GERALDINE. You won't let me forget it. (She places paper in safe, closes door and pretends to twirl a dial, MRS. HARDNUT watching her through lorgnette.)

MRS. HARDNUT. If my nephew comes in before I retire send him to my room. I must make him understand that I cannot give him more money to squander foolishly. Also, tell Mary that I found a speck of dust on my mirror this morning. And as for you, just forget about that million dollars. (She exits at Right.)

GERALDINE. And as for you—pooh! (Enter Mary, Left.) Mary, Mrs. Hardnut told me to tell you that she found a speck of dust on her mirror this morning.

MARY. Oh, I'm so sorry!

GERALDINE. Mary Jones, you're a simp. You let that old hag walk all over you.

MARY. But if she is paying me to keep the place clean I should keep it clean.

GERALDINE. I often wonder about you. I can't figure out whether you're really a goody-goody angel, or whether you're pulling some kind of a game.

MARY. I don't know what you mean by pulling some kind of a game.

GERALDINE. You wouldn't. You'd better get that speck off her mirror. She'll begin to think it's a mole on her chin. (Exit MARY, Right. Enter HAROLD, Left.)

HAROLD. Hello, hon'. Anything new?

GERALDINE (Looks cautiously around, then confidentially.) There's a million dollars worth of stock in that safe.

HAROLD. A million! How do you know?

GERALDINE. I put it there. You know the combination.

HAROLD. Do you think I'm a fool?

GERALDINE. I don't want to commit myself.

HAROLD. Wise cracks don't fit your makeup. Listen. If that safe is opened it's got to be by some other way than the combination. It's got to look like an outside, not an inside, job.

GERALDINE. And so what? Anyway it's done, I get my cut.

HAROLD. What's the matter? Don't you trust me?

GERALDINE. Frankly, no. You're so crooked your shadow looks like a coil spring. You've got the dope now. It's up to you.

HAROLD. That means I've got to get Pinsetti Penicilli at once. He can open that safe in no time.

GERALDINE. But if he's caught he'll get plenty time.

HAROLD. We—I mean, he won't get caught. Now beat it before the old woman sees us together. (GERALDINE exits, Right. HAROLD picks up phone. Tiptoes to door, Right. Phone has no connecting cord. He then crosses stealthily to door, Left. Then back to Center. Calls central.) Give me Columbus 1492—Pinsetti . . . Got a job for you. . . Meet me by the tree . . . What tree? . . . Fool, there's only one tree in Brooklyn. Right away. (Sets down phone and exits at Left. Enter MARY, Right. JACK tiptoes on from Right.)

JACK (Cautiously calls.) Mary. Hist! Mary!

MARY (Startled, turns.) Jack! How did you get here?

JACK. In the basement window and up through the laundry chute.

MARY. Oh, Jack, you shouldn't come here. Mrs. Hardnut doesn't want you here.

JACK. Maybe if she saw this she'd change her mind about me. (*Holds out legal looking paper.*) My diploma.

MARY. Of what?

JACK. Got it from the correspondence school. I'm a regular detective now.

MARY. Oh, my sweetheart! Have you caught any criminals yet?

JACK. I ran down a couple of rubber heels. See my badge? (*Shows her his badge.*)

MARY. Oh, how pretty. Don't let anybody take it away from you.

JACK. I solved one great mystery already.

MARY. What was it?

JACK. Boarding house hash. Only ten percent food in it. The rest is ingredients.

MARY. Detective! Now you're just like Sholock Harms.

JACK. You mean Sherlock Sharms—Harlock Shomes—Sherlock Holmes. (*Hears someone coming.*) Who's it?

MARY. You must go! Quick! Hide in the broom closet. There's nobody there but another mop. (*Pushes him off Right. Then hides behind davenport. Enter HAROLD and PINSETTI, Left. HAROLD wears mask.*)

HAROLD. Now quiet!

PINSETTI (*In booming voice.*) Sure, all-a time, quiet, like-a da mice.

HAROLD. Now get this straight. (*Whispers in PINSETTI's ear.*) Now get out! Watch out for cops. You've spent most of your life in jail already.

PINSETTI. Maybe I should get-a in-a jail once-a more quick.

HAROLD. Why?

PINSETTI. I want to see maybe I get-a some mail. (*Laughs very loud and exits, Left. MARY comes from behind davenport and bravely faces HAROLD.*)

MARY. Who are you?

HAROLD (*Startled.*) Where'd you come from?

MARY. I think you are a robber and I'm going to call the police...

HAROLD. You vixen! (*He grabs her, placing his hand over her mouth. Pulls a short rope from his pocket and very loosely wraps it about her, including her arms. She struggles very feebly. He*

takes handkerchief from his pocket and ties it over her nose.) Now, girl, you're bound hand and foot and gagged. Now for the nitro-glycerine. (*Takes pint bottle of milk from his pocket and removes cap. Drinks a little.*) Yes, it's nitro-glycerine, but there's a lot of butter fat in it. (*Goes to safe and pours some of the bottle's contents on the safe. Lights firecracker fuse and steps back. Firecracker explodes. HAROLD steps to safe, opens safe door and takes out roll of wallpaper and a sheet of typewriting paper. Tosses typewriting paper aside and crosses to Right with wallpaper. Then runs across to Left and exits. MARY struggles with bonds but seems to be unable to extricate herself.*)

MARY (*In muffled voice.*) He'p! (*Enter JACK, Left. Looks about but does not see MARY although he walks around her two or three times.*)

JACK. I'd a sworn I heard a woman scream. (*MARY tries to scream, but scream is muffled. JACK looks directly at her.*) Did you hear anything? (*Looks about, puzzled.*)

MARY (*Weakly.*) He'p!

JACK. For land's sake, Mary! Why didn't you say you were bound and gagged. (*Removes handkerchief from over her nose.*) Who done this?

MARY. Not done. Did. A robber burglarized the safe.

JACK. You mean a burglar robbed the safe? (*He does not remove rope from MARY. Looks at safe.*) It's safe to say that that safe is not as safe as some safes I've seen. (*Goes to safe and picks up paper. Holds it up. A life size man's hand is painted a solid black on the paper.*) Ah! Ah-ah-ah! Ah-ah-ah-ah-ah! A fingerprint! The robber left a fingerprint.

MARY. Let me see. (*Holds up the paper.*) Jack, that's Harold Hardnut's fingerprint. I would recognize it anywhere. It's the same one he leaves on the sugar spoon.

JACK (*Takes spyglass from pocket and gets on hands and knees before safe.*) Ah! Ah-ah-ah! Ah-ah-ah-ah-ah! Mary, did the robber limp?

MARY. A little in both feet.

JACK. I thought so. (*Touches finger to floor, then places it to nose.*) Mary, the burglar had talcum powder in his socks and a hole in his shoes. (*Follows tracks to door at Left, then crosses to Right.*) Mary, do you know anybody that uses talcum powder in his socks?

MARY. Harold Hardnut does. He even stole my face powder to put in his socks.

JACK. And you had the face to let him have it?

MARY. He had the feet to take it.

JACK. He should use flea powder on his dogs. But I must dog his dogfeet . . . I mean dog his footsteps—footsteeps—I must follow him while the trail is hot—dogs. (*Exits Left on hands and knees. Enter Mrs. HARDNUT, Left. Stares at open safe.*)

Mrs. HARDNUT. Mary Jones, you robbed my safe.

MARY. Oh, no, Mrs. Hardnut. It was your nephew!

Mrs. HARDNUT. My dear, sweet nephew robbed me? No, no! I am going to faint! (*Carefully sits on floor and lies back in faint. Sits up.*) If anyone calls tell them I'm in a faint. (*Lies back. Enter PINSETTI Right, dressed in policeman's coat and cap. Has sword, hatchet and club attached to belt. Carries a shotgun and revolver. Has black mask over face.*)

PINSETTI (*To Mary.*) Hands up!

MARY. I cannot obey the command, sir, because I am bound hand and foot.

PINSETTI. Oh, please-a excuse. (*Lays down guns and removes rope from MARY. Picks up guns.*) Hands up! (*MARY raises hands.*) Now you come-a wid me. I am one-a beeg p'liceman. (*Enter JACK at Left, with slingshot aimed at PINSETTI.*)

JACK. Arms up! Also hands! (*PINSETTI raises hands.*) Mary, relieve the gentleman of his arsenal. Notice how like a cucumber I am, Mary? Cool like ice.

MARY. I thought you were cold. You're shivering. Sh! Don't wake up Mrs. Hardnut. She fainted.

JACK. Mary, take that rope and securely bind this man.

PINSETTI (*Takes the mask from his face.*) You can no do eet to me. (*JACK threatens him with a slingshot.*) Well, don't tie da rope too-a tight.

JACK. Mary, you tie him up while I go after the robber. (*Exits, Left.*)

PINSETTI. Please-a, nice-a girl. Please-a let-a me go!

MARY. No. You are a criminal and must go to jail for your crimes.

PINSETTI. Oh, please-a, nice-a girl. I go-a to-a de jail my kids dey starve-a to death an' die. An' my poor-a wife . . .

MARY. You have a wife?

PINSETTI. Please-a, nice-a girl. I got-a two, tree, four wives.

MARY. You poor man!

PINSETTI. Den you no tie-a me up?

MARY. Yes, but not so tight. Why don't you turn over a new leaf?

PINSETTI. What's da use? I can no read, anyhoo? (*Enter HAROLD at Left, followed by JACK who has a slingshot aimed at HAROLD's back.*)

PINSETTI. He ketch-a you, too?

HAROLD. Shut up!

PINSETTI. Sure, just-a like you say. What you do wid stuff from-a da safe?

JACK. Don't worry about that. I turned it over to the police. They'll soon be here after you two. (*Enter GERALDINE, Right.*)

GERALDINE (*Screams.*) Oh!

HAROLD. You better scream, you she wolf. You double-crosser! You engineered this so we'd get caught.

GERALDINE (*Draws herself up straight.*) I know nothing about it.

JACK (*Points a slingshot at her.*) You're under arrest. (*Sleighbells offstage.*) Hark! The patrol wagon is here. Now you three march out and get in the patrol. I'll stay in here. (*GERALDINE, PINSETTI and HAROLD, with heads down, slowly exeunt Left.*)

Mrs. HARDNUT (*Sits up.*) Who was that?

JACK. I am a detective. I just caught those who robbed your safe.

Mrs. HARDNUT. Who was it?

MARY. Geraldine Lemon, Pinsetti Penicilli and Harold Hardnut.

Mrs. HARDNUT (*Leaps to her feet and gets a cramp in her leg.*) Ouch! I'll disown that scoundrel. I will adopt you, Mary, and make you my heiress and you can marry this detective and live happy ever after. What is your name, young man?

JACK. Jack Hart. Your wallpaper stock—I mean your Wall Street stock is safe with the police. (*Sleighbells offstage.*) There go the criminals to their just deserts.

JACK, MARY and Mrs. HARDNUT (*Face the audience and speak in unison.*) Crime does not pay!

CURTAIN